
Networks under Surveillance: Source Bias and Historical Network Reconstruction in Revolutionary Iran

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Abstract

This paper examines how authoritarian and post-authoritarian source regimes shape the reconstruction of historical networks, drawing on an ongoing PhD project on the local history of the Iranian Revolution (1977–1979) in the northern province of Gilan. It addresses a central problem in historical network research: how networks reconstructed from politically conditioned sources reflect the logic of their production rather than underlying social relations (Lemercier 2015).

Using three principal source types—SAVAK surveillance files, local press, and oral history interviews—the paper reconstructs and compares actor networks through qualitative network coding and basic structural measures, focusing on node visibility, tie density, and brokerage. SAVAK documents, produced within an authoritarian surveillance apparatus and selectively published after 1979 by the Islamic Republic, disproportionately record actors deemed threatening by the state. As a result, networks derived from these sources tend to overrepresent politically visible religious activists while obscuring informal brokers, conservative clerics, and socially embedded actors whose influence operated outside the regime’s field of vision. In such cases, network centrality often reflects patterns of repression rather than political influence, illustrating how states produce legible but partial representations of society (Scott 1998).

Oral history interviews provide access to otherwise invisible ties but introduce a different set of distortions. Interviewees’ narratives are shaped by post-revolutionary legitimacy, retrospective self-positioning, and selective amnesia, frequently reconfiguring past relationships to align with later political outcomes (Portelli 1991). Comparing networks reconstructed from surveillance files and interviews reveals systematic divergences in node prominence and perceived brokerage roles.

Rather than treating these distortions as methodological failures, the paper argues that network analysis can serve as a diagnostic tool for identifying the epistemological conditions under which historical sources were produced and curated. It highlights the need for interpretive, multi-source approaches to historical network reconstruction, particularly in authoritarian and post-authoritarian contexts.

References

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